Bulk Text Replacement for Word – User Manual

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Getting started

Opening the application

- **From file explorer**: Right-click on a Word document → "Open with" → Select the Python script or use the context menu entry.
- **From command line**: python word_text_replacer_single_with_add.py [optional_file_path].
- **Direct launch**: Double-click the Python script or the executable.

Interface overview

The application features:

- **File management section**: Add, remove, and manage Word documents (hyperlink check included).
- **nbsp check:** Check your search/replace box for non-breaking spaces.
- **Search box**: Enter text to find.
- **Replace box**: Enter replacement text.
- **Options**: Backup creation, case sensitivity, Regex (Standard replace only), Whole word match.
- **Action buttons**: Preview, Standard Replace & Advanced Replace.
- **Real-time match counter:** Counts matches in main content (paragraphs + tables), not text boxes/headers/footers. So "Live: 0 matches" doesn't mean Advanced Replace will also find nothing.

File management

Adding files

- **Add more files button**: Select multiple Word documents (.docx, .doc, .docm).
- **Keyboard shortcut**: Ctrl+O

Managing files

- **Remove selected**: Select files in the list and click "Remove selected" or press Delete.
- **Clear all**: Remove all files from the list.
- **File count**: Displayed in the bottom-right of the file section.

Text input features

Search and Replace boxes

- **Multi-line support**: Both boxes support multiple lines of text.
- **Tab navigation**: Use Tab to move between boxes.
- **Undo/Redo:** Ctrl+Z (undo), Ctrl+Y (redo)

Paste clipboard feature

- 📋 **Paste clipboard buttons**: Available for both search and replace boxes.
- **Function**: Instantly paste clipboard content, replacing existing text.
- **Use case**: Quickly insert copied text from other applications.

Non-breaking spaces

Non-breaking spaces (nbsp) prevent line breaks between words and are common in professional documents.

How to insert:

1. **Shortcut method**: Press Shift+Space in either text box.
2. **Manual method**: Type _nbsp_ anywhere in your text.

Processing:

- The application automatically converts _nbsp_ placeholders to actual non-breaking spaces.
- 🔍 **nbsp check:** Shows count of non-breaking spaces in your search/replace text.
- **Use cases**: Maintaining formatting in text, preventing awkward line breaks.

Replacement methods

Standard Replace (⚡ Fast)

Speed: Very fast processing

Coverage: Main document content only

- ✅ Paragraphs and text
- ✅ Tables and cells
- ❌ Headers and footers
- ❌ Shapes and text boxes
- ❌ Footnotes and endnotes
- ❌ Form fields

Hyperlink behavior:

- ⚠️ **Important**: Updates hyperlink display text but **removes the actual link**.
- Only use if you're not modifying hyperlink text!

Best for:

- Large documents without “special content like shapes, forms …).
- Simple text replacements.
- When speed is priority.
- Documents without hyperlinks in replacement areas.

Advanced Replace (🔧 Comprehensive)

Speed: Slower processing (uses Microsoft Word).

Coverage: Complete document coverage.

- ✅ All Standard Replace areas
- ✅ Headers and footers
- ✅ Shapes and text boxes
- ✅ Footnotes and endnotes
- ✅ Form fields
- ✅ **Hyperlinks (preserves links while updating display text)**

Hyperlink behavior:

- ✅ **Preserves hyperlinks** while updating display text.
- Safe for documents with hyperlinks.

Best for:

- Documents with hyperlinks.
- Complex documents with headers/footers.
- Documents with shapes or text boxes.
- When complete coverage is needed.

Best practices

When to use Standard Replace

- ✅ Large batch operations (100+ files).
- ✅ Simple text in paragraphs and tables.
- ✅ No hyperlinks in replacement text.
- ✅ Speed is important.
- ✅ Basic formatting preservation.

When to use Advanced Replace

- ✅ Documents with hyperlinks being modified.
- ✅ Text in headers, footers, or shapes.
- ✅ Complex documents with multiple content areas.
- ✅ Complete coverage needed.
- ✅ Professional document formatting.

File preparation tips

1. **Close Word documents**: Ensure files aren't open in Microsoft Word.
2. **Backup important files**: Enable backup option for critical documents.
3. **Test first**: Use preview to verify matches before replacing.
4. **Check hyperlinks**: Run hyperlink check for documents with links.

Hyperlink management

Hyperlink check feature

🔗 **Hyperlink check button**: Scans selected files for hyperlinks.

What it shows:

- Total hyperlinks found.
- Files containing hyperlinks.

Recommendations:

- **No hyperlinks found**: Both methods are safe to use.
- **Hyperlinks found**:
  - Use **Advanced Replace** if modifying hyperlink display text.
  - Use **Standard Replace** if not touching hyperlink text (faster).

Hyperlink safety guidelines

Scenario	Standard Replace	Advanced Replace
No hyperlinks in document	✅ Safe & fast	✅ Safe but slower
Hyperlinks present, not being modified	✅ Safe & fast	✅ Safe
Hyperlinks present, display text being modified	❌ Breaks links	✅ Preserves links

Preview options

Standard Preview (fast)

- **Coverage**: Main content only (paragraphs + tables).
- **Speed**: Very fast.
- **Use**: Quick check for main document text.
- **Matches**: Shows what Standard Replace will find, including up to 5 context snippets per file that highlight exactly where each match appears in the surrounding text.

Advanced Preview (comprehensive)

- **Coverage**: All document areas (same as Advanced Replace).
- **Speed**: Slower (uses Microsoft Word).
- **Use**: Complete analysis of all document areas.
- **Matches**: Shows what Advanced Replace will find.

Options and settings

Backup files

- **Purpose**: Creates safety copies before modification.
- **File Extension**: .backup added to original filename.
- **Example**: forza_inter.docx → forza_inter.docx.backup.

Restore from backup

1. **Locate backup**: Find the .backup file in the same folder.
2. **Remove extension**: Remove the .backup extension by renaming the file.

Case sensitivity

- **Unchecked** (default): Case-insensitive search ("Hello" matches "hello", "HELLO").
- **Checked**: Case-sensitive search ("Hello" only matches "Hello"). Works with both Standard and Advanced Replace.

Regex

- **Unchecked** (default): Regex is not used. The search text is treated as plain text.
- **Checked:** The search pattern uses Python regex syntax (e.g., \d+, (foo|bar)). Works only with Standard Preview and Standard Replace — Advanced Preview/Replace uses Word's native search engine, which does not support Python regex.

Whole word match

- **Unchecked** (default)**:** Matches the search text wherever it appears, including inside longer words (e.g., "use" matches "use", "reuse", "useful").
- **Checked:** Matches only complete, standalone words (e.g., "use" matches "use" but not "reuse" or "useful"). Works with both Standard and Advanced Replace.

Keyboard shortcuts

Global shortcuts (work anywhere)

Shortcut	Action
F5	Preview
Ctrl+Enter	Standard Replace
Ctrl+Shift+Enter	Standard Replace & Close application
Shift+Enter	Advanced Replace
Ctrl+O	Add more files
Escape or Ctrl+Q	Close application

Navigation

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl+1	Focus Search box
Ctrl+2	Focus Replace box
Tab	Switch between boxes

Text editing

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl+Tab	Insert tab character (\t)
Ctrl+Z	Undo
Ctrl+Y	Redo
Shift+Space	Insert non-breaking space (*nbsp*)

File management (when file list is focused)

Shortcut	Action
Delete	Remove selected files

Technical requirements

- **Python 3.x** with tkinter (not needed when using the executable)
- **python-docx** library (not needed when using the executable)
- **Microsoft Word** (for Advanced Replace)
- **Word COM automation** (pywin32) for advanced document operations.
- **Windows**

Troubleshooting

Common Issues

"Document is locked": Close the file in Microsoft Word before processing.

"Permission denied": Ensure you have write access to the file location.

Error recovery

- **Backup files**: Always available if backup option was enabled.
- **Partial processing**: If some files fail, successful ones are still processed.
- **Error messages**: Detailed error information provided in results window.

All good things come to an end and so does this manual. 😊 But before finalizing it, one more thing: The tool is free and I am happy with sharing it with whoever wants to use it. If you want, you can buy me a coffee. ☕ 🙏 And connect with me!